10

Building Beliefs into Edifices

ASHOKA'S INITIATIVES AND ORDERS, MADE KNOWN across his empire through epigraphs addressed to his subjects, are only one of the constitutive elements of the emperor's authority. There are important others, of a qualitatively different order, which too left a material imprint. Among these are Ashoka's royal programmes for building, renovating, and modifying religious edifices. His epigraphs pertaining to these programmes are largely about religion, religious personages, and interventions regarding the practice of his new faith.

The range of such structures is as diverse as the places where they were constructed. Some are caves that the sovereign got excavated as abodes for ascetics. Others are spaces sedimented with Buddhist associations where Ashoka's stamp can be seen because he journeyed there as a pilgrim. He installed numerous pillars at places that had featured in some way in the life and death of the Buddha; others at places the Buddha could not have visited. Stupas too were built with Ashoka's patronage, sometimes over relics of the Sakyamuni that he is believed to have extracted out of older stupas. The stunning pillared hall in the Magadhan capital, which is likely to have been built in his time, may well carry the same religious associations.

The points in time of their construction remain uncertain in a significant number of instances. Unlike the edicts, the chronology of the edifices usually cannot be delineated with the same degree of accuracy. Among the epigraphs of the emperor which adorn several of these structures, only some bear dates in relation to the king's consecration, dates which would make it